



Culturally responsive evaluation: A scoping review of the evaluation literature

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Culturally responsive evaluation
Evaluation
Culture
Scoping review
Review

ABSTRACT

Evaluators have become increasingly aware of the influence of culture in evaluation, leading to new evaluation approaches that account for the cultural considerations in which evaluations are situated. This scoping review sought to explore how evaluators understand culturally responsive evaluation and identify promising practices. A search of nine evaluation journals yielded 52 articles that were included in this review. Nearly two-thirds of the articles stated that community involvement was essential to culturally responsive evaluation. Power differentials were discussed in almost half of the articles, and the majority used participatory or collaborative approaches to community engagement. Findings from this review suggest that in culturally responsive evaluation, evaluators prioritize community involvement and have an awareness and attentiveness to power differentials. Yet, gaps exist in how culture and evaluation are defined and interpreted, and consequently, inconsistency in how culturally responsive evaluation is practiced.

1. Introduction

This paper presents a scoping review of the evaluation literature on culturally responsive evaluation (CRE). Purposefully written for those new to CRE, whether evaluators or community practitioners, this paper serves to present a broad overview of CRE and offer some practical guidance for incorporating CRE into evaluation practice. The paper begins with a brief introduction and history of CRE, followed by the scoping review methods and findings, and concludes with practical recommendations and resources.

Evaluations in the social serving sector are essential for understanding the impact of programs, practices and policies, and to assess whether they are effective and responsive to the needs of individuals and communities. There is increasing awareness that evaluation can also be culturally bound, rooted in the cultural norms and background of the initiative itself, its community members, and broader cultural structures, histories, and norms (Askew et al., 2012; Kirkhart, 2011). As multiple layers of culture influence the lived experiences of the recipients of social programs, there is also a need to consider culture when

evaluating these initiatives. This has given rise to increasing attention to the relevance of culture in evaluation, and emergence of the concept of culturally responsive evaluation within the evaluation field. Kirkhart (2010) describes the multi-faceted nature of culture, proposing that it is determined at the individual and collective levels, is a dynamic concept that shifts according to its context, and is correlated to power. In recent years, dissonance in worldview and perception between evaluators and community members has drawn attention to the role of culture in evaluation, raising questions around power dynamics and the appropriateness of Western methodologies, as well as the social justice implications and validity of outcomes against the backdrop of culture (Chouinard & Cousins, 2009; SenGupta et al., 2004). To advance the principles of equity, diversity, inclusion, decolonization, and Indigenization (Eaton, 2022) in the social serving sector, it is important for evaluators and practitioners to place the cultural and sociopolitical context of the community at the forefront of their work.

Literature on culture in evaluation often uses the phrase, 'cultural context' to describe the cultural structures, histories, and norms that influence the evaluation process. As Easton (2012) states, "the

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profession [of evaluation] suffers from a history of inappropriate use of evaluation methods" (p. 516) in environments of multiple cultures. As evaluators have become increasingly aware of the influence of culture, new evaluation approaches that address the role of culture have emerged. A variety of terms have been used in the evaluation literature to describe these approaches, including cross-cultural (Garaway, 1996; Merryfield, 1985; Rhodes, 2016), culturally competent (Morris, 2014; Prado, 2011; Symonette, 2004), culturally appropriate (Cohen, 2012; Howard, 2017); culturally relevant (Collier et al., 2018; McBride, 2011), culturally congruent (Kirkhart, 2010), and culturally responsive evaluation (Acree & Chouinard, 2020; Hood, 2001; Manswell-Butty et al., 2004; Thomas & Parsons, 2017). Drawing on a range of disciplines and theoretical backgrounds, all of these approaches attempt to directly account for and incorporate culture in evaluation. This review uses the term 'culturally responsive evaluation' to recognize the expanding application of this term across multiple fields of study. Culturally responsive evaluation is broadly defined as an evaluation approach that "recognizes that demographic, sociopolitical, and contextual dimensions, locations, perspectives, and characteristics of culture matter fundamentally in evaluation" (Hopson, 2009, p. 4), where lived experiences help to (re)define and (re)interpret evaluation outcomes.

The interaction between culture and evaluation has been recognized for decades, albeit inconsistently and by some researchers and fields more than others. The earliest known examples of evaluations that critically considered culture occurred between the 1930 s and 1950 s by African American researchers who incorporated racial segregation and lived experiences of segregation into their evaluative studies with African American communities (Chouinard & Cousins, 2009). Stake's (1975) responsive evaluation emerged two decades later as a participatory approach that acknowledged community members' diverse positions, interests, and perspectives, without explicitly identifying matters of culture (Hall et al., 2020; Hopson, 2009).

In the following years, as race-based theories and agendas of social justice, inclusion, and diversity gained traction across the social science disciplines, responsive evaluation was increasingly coupled with cultural considerations (Chouinard & Cousins, 2009; Hopson, 2009). Merryfield (1985) first drew attention to cultural competence in cross-cultural evaluation settings by identifying the incongruence of Western evaluation methods in non-Western settings as potential barriers to practical evaluation (SenGupta et al., 2004). When Kirkhart (1994) identified cultural aspects as central to evaluation validity in her presidential address to the American Evaluation Association (AEA), acknowledging multicultural influences and environments became more formally recognized in evaluative practice (Botcheva et al., 2009; Chouinard & Cousins, 2009). Since this time, core documents from the AEA have promoted CRE practice on a larger scale, building evaluators' knowledge and application of cultural awareness in evaluation design, implementation, analysis and translation, and progressively integrating concepts of culture with evaluation practice (Botcheva et al., 2009; Chouinard & Cousins, 2009; King & Stevahn, 2020).

1.1. Purpose and study context

To understand how evaluation can become a community-driven and culturally responsive mechanism for improving practices and programs in the social serving sector, research teams at universities across Canada and the United States (University of Alberta, Queen's University, University of Ottawa, Lakehead University, Claremont Graduate University) collaborated on five complementary scoping reviews (Bourgeois et al., 2023; Puinean et al., 2022). A scoping review is a methodological process for systematically exploring a broad literature base on a specific topic and synthesizing the available research evidence (Munn et al., 2018). The purpose of these complementary reviews was to contribute to our understanding of four key constructs in the evaluation literature: community-driven evaluation, culturally responsive evaluation, evaluation capacity building, and evaluation use and influence.

Although the importance of culture in evaluation has been increasingly recognized, and much has been written about the topic, we are unaware of a practically oriented summary of this literature that foregrounds common and best practices currently being applied. While Acree and Chouinard (2020) explored use and influence in CRE within a North American context, the purpose of this scoping review is to explore and summarize how evaluators understand and practice culturally responsive evaluation, with the intention of providing practical guidance for evaluators to conduct CRE more generally. This review was guided by the following research questions: What is the current state of knowledge on CRE? Specifically, what is CRE, how is it understood by evaluators, and how is it practiced?

2. Methods

This scoping review was conducted according to the methodological framework developed by Arksey and O'Malley (2005), with enhancements as recommended by Levac et al. (2010) and reported in adherence to the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic reviews and Meta-Analyses extension for Scoping Reviews (PRISMA-ScR; Tricco et al., 2018). The scoping review methodology is unique for this particular construct as culturally responsive evaluation has, to date, not been systematically explored using this methodology. This systematic approach to searching for evidence enabled us to map a portion of the evaluation literature as it relates to CRE—particularly, the ways in which it is understood and practiced—making an important contribution to the field. As this review did not involve human participants or the use of personal data, ethics approval was not required.

2.1. Identifying relevant sources of evidence

The focus of this review was to explore how evaluators understand and practice CRE, and for this reason, the search was limited to evaluation journals (i.e., American Journal of Evaluation, Canadian Journal of Program Evaluation, New Directions for Evaluation, Journal of Multi-Disciplinary Evaluation, Evaluation, Evaluation and Program Planning, Evaluation Journal of AustralAsia, Evaluation Matters, and Evaluation in the Health Professions). The search string is shown in Table 1. The study was conducted from October 2020—August 2021. The most recent search was conducted in January 2022 and no new studies were identified. Unique to this scoping review, we included community partners in the analysis and interpretation of findings. These included the (Evaluation Capacity Network) steering committee as well as its partners who represent researchers, evaluators, leaders of community-based organizations, students, and funders across Canada and the United States. We collaborated with these community partners to verify the review findings, which was achieved by comparing findings with partners' experiences and perspectives.

2.2. Selecting sources of evidence

Articles that contained at least one of the keywords in their title or abstract and had a primary or secondary emphasis on CRE were advanced to full screening. A heuristic approach was adopted using the research questions with the ultimate goal of identifying promising practices and evaluation tools, toolkits, and resources that support CRE. Articles that emphasized a specific type or approach to cultural evaluation (e.g., Indigenous evaluation, evaluation with immigrant and

Table 1

Search String.

[All "culture"] OR [All "culturally responsive"] OR [All "culturally relevant"] OR [All "cultural responsiveness"] OR [All "cultural competence"] OR [All "cultural competency"] OR [All "cross-cultural"] OR [All "cultural appropriateness"] OR [All "cultural context"] within [Journal]

refugee populations) and did not include a more general exploration of CRE, were excluded. This was done to maintain our focus on defining CRE more broadly and explore CRE approaches that are recommended, regardless of cultural group. Articles that described culturally responsive programming but did not emphasize culture in its evaluation were also excluded. Similarly, a broad definition of culture that includes racial, ethnic, linguistic, religious, spiritual, and other characteristics has been applied to this study.² Searches were limited to English language articles, and no date restrictions were applied to this review to encompass all relevant articles over time. A search of grey literature was not included (refer to Table 2 for inclusion and exclusion criteria).

In the screening stage, search results were downloaded into Zotero™ referencing software (Corporation for Digital Scholarship) and then uploaded to Covidence™ systematic review software (Veritas Health Innovation, Melbourne, Australia). Two reviewers (LK, MT) screened all the articles' titles and abstracts. There was 96% agreement between the two reviewers, and disagreements were resolved through discussion with all team members.

2.3. Charting the data

In the third stage of the review, full-text screening and extraction were conducted by one reviewer (LK). Data was extracted from full text articles into an Excel spreadsheet that captured relevant information on the characteristics of the articles (i.e., year of publication, journal of

Table 2
Eligibility Criteria.

Inclusion	Exclusion
Includes one or more of the following keywords in its title or abstract: "culture", "culturally responsive", "culturally relevant", "cultural responsiveness", "cultural competence", "cultural competency", "cross-cultural", "cultural appropriateness", or "cultural context"	Does not include one or more of the keywords in title or abstract
Primary or secondary emphasis on CRE	Primary emphasis on a specific type of cultural evaluation (e.g., Indigenous evaluation, immigrant and refugee groups), no emphasis on culturally responsive evaluation more broadly.
Addresses one or more of the research questions and could inform the development of a CRE toolkit	Does not address one or more of the research questions and could not inform the development of a CRE toolkit
Literature reviews (narrative, systemic, meta-analytic); articles presenting evaluations or research on evaluation (using either qualitative, quantitative, or mixed methods); frameworks (guidelines); method/practice notes; commentaries; final synthesis chapters; and articles focused on teaching or providing training on culturally responsive evaluation	Book reviews, editor's notes, psychometric articles
English language	Articles published in languages other than English

² The rationale behind excluding articles that emphasize a specific type of cultural evaluation is that the purpose of the review was to summarize the literature on CRE in general; that is, to provide an introduction and guidance to evaluators looking to conduct CRE. In addition, this review sought to identify general principles for conducting CRE, rather than how to work with specific cultural groups. We recognize that there is a body of literature specifically devoted to Indigenous methodologies and Indigenous evaluation, which would be a very valuable area to conduct a scoping review on.

publication, discipline), methodology (i.e., type of article, data collection methods used), and article content (i.e., information of relevance to the research questions, the term used to refer to culture within the evaluation process, setting, and cultural group of focus). Data was charted independently (LK) for both included and excluded articles, and the results were discussed and confirmed by all members of the review team. Articles excluded from the review during the full screening process were documented on a separate Excel sheet with corresponding reasons for exclusion.

3. Results

This section presents a descriptive summary of the individual sources of evidence and their characteristics. This is followed by a thematic analysis of included studies to answer the questions "What is CRE and how is it understood by evaluators?" and "How is CRE practiced?" A total of 2787 articles were retrieved using our search strategy. After title, abstract and full-text screening, 52 articles were included in this review. See Fig. 1 for the PRISMA flow diagram.

3.1. Study characteristics

Table 3 summarizes the characteristics of included studies. Of the 52 articles reviewed, articles were published between 1985 and 2020, and represented various article types such as opinion/reflection articles (n = 22), evaluation case applications (n = 10), frameworks for practicing CRE (n = 9), research on CRE (n = 6), literature reviews (n = 3), and teaching CRE (n = 2). Of the 10 evaluation case applications, more than half used mixed methodologies followed by qualitative methodology. Eligible articles were found in six of the nine journals searched, including the *American Journal of Evaluation* (n = 17), *Evaluation* (n = 3), *New Directions in Evaluation* (n = 17), *Evaluation and Program Planning* (n = 9), the *Evaluation Journal of AustralAsia* (n = 5), and the *Canadian Journal of Program Evaluation* (n = 1). The majority of articles did not specify a particular discipline or field of study; others came from the fields of education, health, evaluation, international development, and business. "Culturally responsive" was the most commonly used term to refer to culture in the context of evaluation, followed by cultural competence, cross-cultural, culturally appropriate, and culturally relevant.

3.2. Thematic analysis of studies

A thematic analysis of the data extracted from included articles identified three areas of focus related to how CRE is understood by evaluators and how it is practiced. These included the four common elements of CRE—community involvement, cultural competence, interpersonal competencies, and shared lived experience—the impact and interaction of power in the CRE, and approaches applied to conducting culturally responsive evaluations.

3.2.1. Elements of culturally responsive evaluations

Through the articles reviewed in this study, many elements of CREs were shared. These include community engagement, cultural competence, interpersonal competencies, and shared lived experience.

3.2.1.1. Community engagement. The majority of articles articulated that community involvement and engagement was essential to CRE (Cohen, 2012; Easton, 2012; Hall et al., 2020; Hood, 2015; Symonette, 2014). While there is variation in the extent and type of community engagement described, in all articles, it referred to, at minimum, the inclusion of community members' perspectives and insights at key stages within the evaluation process. Ensuring community members are engaged meaningfully and obtain benefits from the collaborative process (Alindogan, 2019; Boyce, 2017; Clark, 2019; Collier et al., 2018;

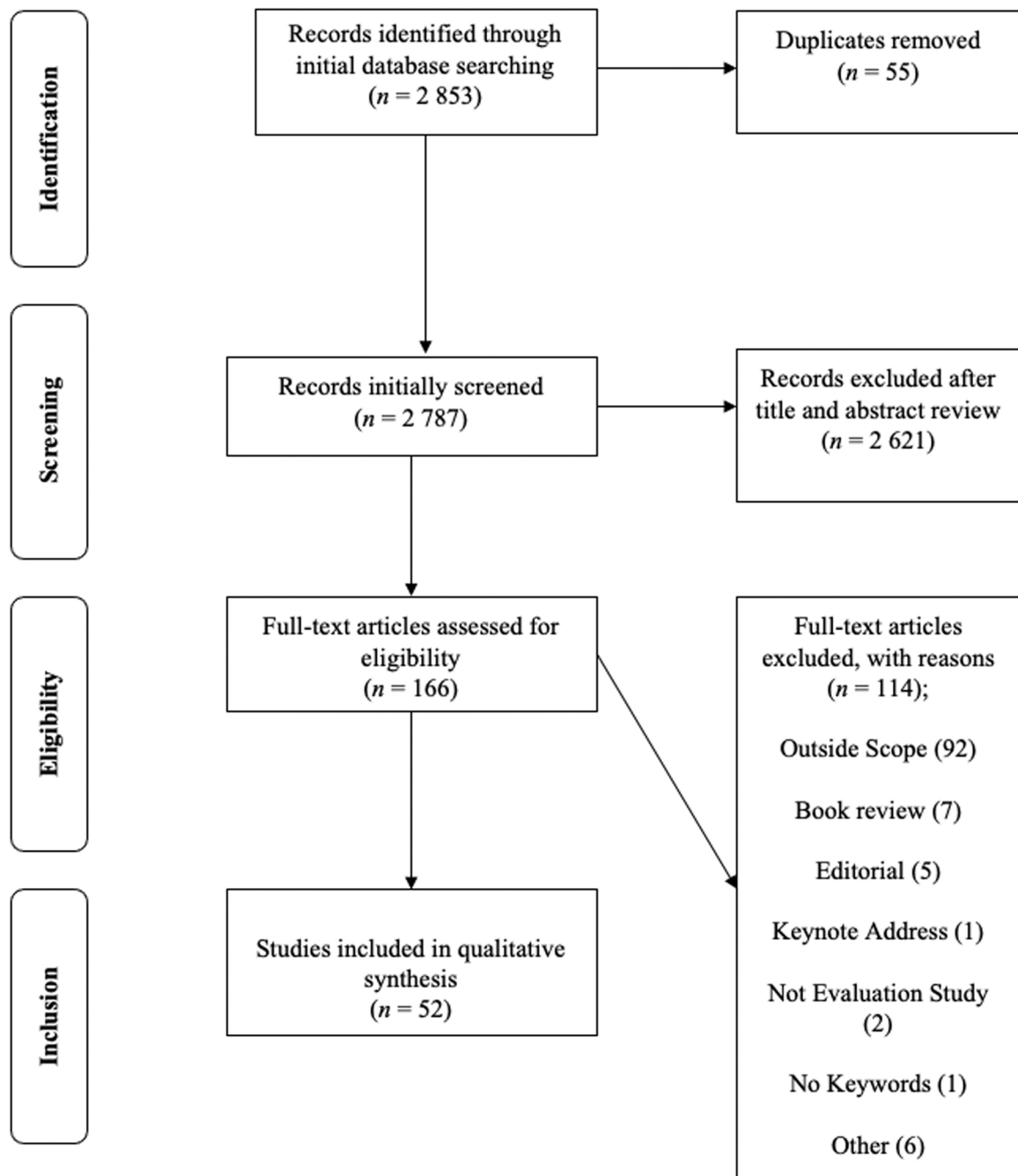


Fig. 1. PRISMA flow diagram.

Rogers et al., 2017; SenGupta et al., 2004; Stitt-Bergh et al., 2016) was important "to avoid making assumptions that may lead to problematic results and ensure that services are suitable, aligned, and tailored to specific community needs" (Aponte-Soto et al., 2014, p. 42).

3.2.1.2. Cultural competence. Cultural competence was described as an essential element of CRE (Botcheva et al., 2009; Clark, 2019; Dunaway et al., 2012; Easton, 2012; McBride, 2011; SenGupta et al., 2004, Stitt-Bergh et al., 2016), and emphasizes evaluators' responsibility to frame "assumptions, knowledge, and meaning from a cultural perspective different than one's own" (Dunaway et al., 2012, p. 497). In some cases, this meant possessing awareness, knowledge, and skills to navigate a new culture (Dunaway et al., 2012), while in other articles this was described as the steps to develop it, including reflection, correction, and adaptation (Botcheva et al., 2009; McBride, 2011; Stitt-Bergh et al.,

2016).

3.2.1.3. Interpersonal competencies. Interpersonal competencies were considered critical to conducting evaluations effectively with different cultural groups (Clark, 2019; Fitzpatrick, 2012; Junge & Negroustoueva, 2019; Stitt-Bergh et al., 2016; Thomas & Parsons, 2017). While interpersonal awareness includes cultural competence, authors also described interpersonal competencies as more general soft skills and professional behaviours, such as punctuality and respect towards community members (Junge & Negroustoueva, 2019), leadership ability (Stitt-Bergh et al., 2016), and awareness of community members' political, social, and environmental contexts (Fitzpatrick, 2012; Thomas & Parsons, 2017).

3.2.1.4. Shared lived experience. Fewer articles shared that conducting

Table 3
Characteristics of Sources of Evidence.

Study (Year)	Geography and/or Population	Study Context	Type of Article ^a	Authored By	Key Findings
Acree & Chouinard (2020)	North America	Review of empirical literature that examines the impact of culturally responsive evaluations in North America	Review	Scholars	Findings and process were determined to be the primary sources of evaluation use, although multidirectional and unintended effects can emerge as a result
Alindogan (2019)	Australia	Examines the functions of professional evaluators in job advertisements	Research on evaluation	Evaluator	Content analysis of evaluator job advertisements revealed cultural competence, a core criterion, was not mentioned
Aponte-Soto et al. (2014)	United States; graduate students of colour	Evaluates the Graduate Education Diversity Internship (GEDI) Program's impact on CRE leadership development	Framework for teaching CRE	Students of colour enrolled in GEDI program	Findings show that participating in evaluation projects enhanced the CRE capacity of GEDI interns, and that relationship-building fostered a sense of community as well as commitment to CRE
Askew et al. (2012)	United States	Authors provide suggestions for aligning collaborative and culturally responsive evaluation approaches	Opinion/ reflection	Scholars and evaluators	Suggests that collaborative evaluation should transfer cultural knowledge between community members and evaluators
Botcheva et al. (2009)	Zimbabwe; Zimbabweans	Evaluating the Grassroot Soccer HIV/ AIDS Prevention Program	Framework/ guideline	Evaluators	Recommends collaboration, adaptation and contextual analysis as strategies to ensure cultural competence
Bowen & Tillman (2015)	Brazil; former fugitive slave communities	ought to develop culturally responsive surveys that would yield useful data on Brazil's former fugitive slave communities	Evaluation case application	Scholars	Findings suggest that it is beneficial to administer a pilot study of survey instruments, involve local residents in training external enumerators, and address the tension between quantitative instrument development and CRE
Boyce (2017)	United States	Reports lessons learned from the evaluation of a STEM education program housed within the NSF Science and Technology Center	Research on evaluation	Scholar	Explicit attention to culture, diversity, and equity were initially challenged by the Center's organizational culture, although evidence of attention to these principles were found in evaluation documents and dialogue
Briggs et al. (2019)	Costa Rica; Latin American children	A case study of collaborative and contextual approaches used in cross-cultural environmental education research	Evaluation case application	Scholars	Highlights importance of collaborating with local partners and creating realistic research agendas, as well as limitations of quantitative methods in this field of research
Chouinard & Cousins (2009)	N/A	A review and synthesis of research on evaluation in cultural communities	Review	Scholars	Findings suggest that culture influences every aspect of an evaluation, and emphasize the need to strengthen relationships between evaluators and community members
Chouinard & Milley (2018)	N/A	Highlights innovative approaches that ensure the inclusion of community members in international development program evaluations	Research on evaluation	Scholars	Discovered creative and innovative techniques for empowering the voices of community members, although these efforts typically focused on gathering data from participants rather than actively engaging them in the evaluation process
Chouinard (2014)	N/A	Offers a critical examination of issues affecting cross cultural-evaluations	Opinion/ reflection	Scholar	Assesses political and ethical considerations, as well as cultural implications of methodologies and research methods selected
Clark (2019)	N/A	Examines cultural responsiveness influences on evaluator consulting practice	Opinion/ reflection	Evaluator	Shares that cultural responsiveness requires a lifelong commitment to understanding and learning, and that reflective practice can help evaluators become more intentional in their work
Cohen (2012)	United States; multi-generational Hmong communities	Summarizes evaluation lessons learned about working with cultural community advisory groups	Opinion/ reflection	Evaluator	Engaging community members from diverse cultural contexts in advisory groups is an effective technique for community-based evaluations as they help build capacity and create space for their voices to be heard
Collier et al. (2018)	Micronesia; Palauans	Describes CBPR needs assessment and role of advisory group in developing obesity intervention program	Evaluation case application	Scholars and practitioners	Lessons learned include devoting enough time to finding effective community organizations to partner with; having a full-time researcher on the ground in community; and striving to understand cultural differences
Collins et al. (2014)	United States; graduate students of colour	Describes the Graduate Education Diversity Internship (GEDI) program that is designed to recruit students of colour and train culturally responsive evaluators	Framework for teaching CRE	Scholars and practitioners	The GEDI program aimed to train young evaluators of colour, yet invited lecturers also reported enhanced professional development; further, networking led to

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Table 3 (continued)

Study (Year)	Geography and/or Population	Study Context	Type of Article ^a	Authored By	Key Findings
Conner (2004)	United States; Latinx males	Explores multicultural validity, combined oral-written-icon approaches used in two HIV prevention programs for Latinx males	Evaluation case application	Scholar	more professional collaborations and intergenerational relationship-building Factors that were found to increase cultural validity include: actively involving community members in the evaluation process; speaking the same literal and figurative language as the participants; collaborating with these members when implementing the evaluation; and sharing recognition for the work that was done
Dahler-Larsen et al. (2017)	N/A	Discusses collaborative work needed to address translation issues in multilingual evaluations	Opinion/reflection	Scholars and evaluators	Recommendations include: highlighting frictions in between evaluator language and local languages; enhancing the language skills of evaluators; making research on frictions in translation a bigger part of the evaluation agenda
Dinh et al. (2019a)	Southeast and East Asia; Buddhist	Explores Buddhist adaptation of <i>Most Significant Change</i> technique	Opinion/reflection	Scholars	Highlights ways in which non-Western worldviews can be used in evaluation methods. Suggests that the ontologies and epistemologies underlying existing methods and alternative worldviews must be unpacked, as should the evaluator's own beliefs and values
Dinh et al. (2019b)	Southeast and East Asia; Confucian	Discusses Confucianist approach to <i>Contribution Analysis</i>	Opinion/reflection	Scholars	Argues that evaluation methods must be modified to reflect the cultural context in which the evaluation is taking place, and that this could be accomplished by either adjusting existing Western methods or by developing new ones
Dunaway et al. (2012)	N/A	Validated <i>Cultural Competence of Program Evaluators (CCPE)</i> scale and assessed effects of cultural competence training	Research on evaluation	Scholars	The CCPE showed moderate to high reliability and validity. The authors state that this tool can help evaluators determine if training is enhancing their cultural competence
Easton (2012)	West Africa; Hausa culture	Explains strategies for employing local proverbs as tools to enhance evaluator competence	Reflection/opinion	Scholar	States that West African proverbs possess qualities that are relevant to evaluation and should be employed in practice
Fitzpatrick (2012)	Western contexts	Reviews literature on contextual factors with focus on local cultures, political and social challenges	Framework	Scholar	Argues that evaluators should consider multiple facets of context, including the program itself, the setting, and political norms of the community members
Garaway (1996)	India; students learning Barati and Devanagari script	Shares insights from a cross-cultural evaluation using a multiple-case replication design to determine the impacts of a simplified script on the acquisition of literacy	Evaluation case application	Scholar	Recommends multiple-case sites and multiple methods to capture cultural complexity in evaluation
Ginsberg (1988)	N/A	Reviews evaluation literature and underscores need to attend to cross-cultural issues in international development evaluation	Opinion/reflection	Scholar	Recommends the use of a checklist describing an evaluator's characteristics (e. g., ethnicity and affiliation of evaluator and other data collectors, time spent in the community, dates data collection occurred)
Hall et al. (2020)	United States; school staff, students, parents, steering committee	Outlines experience of evaluating a professional development school using a CRE approach	Evaluation case application	Scholars	Although the evaluation team was able to employ CRE methods, they faced numerous challenges due to competing interests and organizational pressures. The authors add that managing power imbalances is difficult, as power can be fluid among evaluators and community members
Hood (2001)	United States; African American evaluators	Describes African American evaluator approaches and shared lived experiences	Opinion/reflection	Scholar	Highlights the value of lived experiences, as well as the importance of using qualitative methodologies and of being responsive to community members taking part in the evaluation
Hood (2004)	United States; African American evaluators	Examines evaluation theory with a focus on culture, context, and evaluator credibility	Opinion/reflection	Scholar	Advocates for the use of culturally responsive and social justice-oriented approaches to evaluation, as well as the inclusion of evaluators with shared lived experience throughout the process
Howard (2017)	Australia; Aboriginal children	Shares lessons learned about local knowledge, socio-cultural environment, and remoteness in Indigenous pre-literacy programs	Evaluation case application	Scholar	Discusses the importance of reflective practice to help overcome cultural assumptions and biases; respecting the lived experience and cultural differences of participants; and allotting enough time for participants to decide if they would like to partake in the evaluation. Evaluators must

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Table 3 (continued)

Study (Year)	Geography and/or Population	Study Context	Type of Article ^a	Authored By	Key Findings
Junge and Negroustoueva (2019)	N/A	Provides an overview of evaluation in the context of international development, challenges, and ways to overcoming them	Opinion/ reflection	Evaluators	be careful not to overburden individuals who are already disadvantaged Highlights the need for interpersonal skills, awareness of power dynamics, gender differences, and language issues in international evaluation consultants
Kirkhart (2010)	United States	Addresses multicultural validity and cultural location of theory and context	Opinion/ reflection	Scholar	Argues that validity is the most important element of a good evaluation, and that evaluation theory must be aligned with the cultural context of the community in which the evaluation is taking place
Kirkhart (2011)	United States	Examines cultural influences on multisite evaluation	Opinion/ reflection	Scholar	Consideration of individual and organizational cultures is said to support evaluation influence and validity
Kosoko-Lasaki et al. (2006)	United States; people of colour	Reports a pilot study assessing two questionnaires; the first assessing community beliefs about research, and the second examining the cultural knowledge of clinicians.	Research on CRE	Scholars	Study participants offered feedback on the design of the instruments and changes were made to the following categories: age, education, race, and religion of focus group respondents, as well as level of satisfaction with health care received. A multiple choice design was deemed most appropriate for the clinician instrument
Manswell-Butty et al. (2004)	United States; African American students	Outlines culturally responsive framework for a school-to-career intervention program	Framework/ guideline	Scholars	Highlights the importance of community engagement, contextual relevance, and triangulation of findings in CRE
McBride (2011)	United States	Examines ways that sociocultural theory can strengthen culturally responsive evaluations	Opinion/ reflection	Evaluator	Argues for the application of sociocultural theory in program evaluation, as it can enhance the validity of this work and also help facilitate relationship-building between evaluators and community members
McDonald (1999)	N/A	Reviews cross-cultural evaluation examples and offers guidelines to empower community members	Framework/ guideline	Evaluator	Identified the following factors as important to empowering community members: active participation; an educational focus; the appropriate methodology; provision of feedback; capacity and relationship building; and cross-cultural evaluation teams
Merryfield (1985)	United States	Explored cross-cultural evaluations and effects of cultural differences on design and ethical challenges	Research on evaluation	Evaluator	Interview respondents revealed that cross-cultural evaluation is complex; that using Western methods in non-Western settings creates tensions; cross-cultural evaluators may face ethical dilemmas; and that evaluators in this area are actively trying to improve cross-cultural evaluation
Mertens (2016)	United States	Presents a transformative philosophical framework for understanding the assumptions of evaluators and community members	Framework/ guideline	Scholar	Argues that a transformative framework enables evaluators to reflect on their underlying assumptions, which can in turn enhance the usefulness and responsiveness of the evaluation for community members
Mertens and Hopson (2006)	United States	Explores the application of a transformative framework in conjunction with principles of cultural competency in the context of science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM) programs	Evaluation case application	Scholars	States that STEM programs must do more to address issues of diversity and power and advocates for the development of an evaluation framework that merges transformative and cultural dimensions to better serve underrepresented groups
Morris (2014)	United States	Describes the role of culture and ethics in shaping program evaluation practice	Opinion/ reflection	Scholar	Encourages the application of theories and frameworks typically employed in community psychology, such as ecological perspectives, to the field of program evaluation
Patton (2016)	N/A	Describes ten dimensions of a core culture of evaluative inquiry	Opinion/ reflection	Scholar	Advocates for the development of globally competent evaluators from diverse disciplines who possess world systems knowledge and global systems analysis skills to better tackle global issues
Prado (2011)	United States	Proposes that culturally competent evaluation frameworks must critically examine issues of racial and cultural inequality, with a focus on school systems	Opinion/ reflection	Scholar	Proposes a critically minded multicultural evaluation practice and argues that racial minority evaluators have the potential to challenge power inequalities in evaluation
Rhodes (2016)	Australia; New Zealand; Pacific and Asian countries	Discusses implications of cultural value differences and skills required for evaluators in international development practice	Opinion/ reflection	Evaluator	Proposes a mnemonic for conducting cross-cultural evaluations, which includes using strengths-based approaches, respecting different values and ways of knowing, and

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Table 3 (continued)

Study (Year)	Geography and/or Population	Study Context	Type of Article ^a	Authored By	Key Findings
Rogers et al. (2017)	Australia; Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples	Describes a cultural protocol to be used in evaluation design or implementation with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities	Framework/guideline	Evaluators	sharing findings in culturally appropriate ways The protocol is based on the following key notions: reciprocal respect; cultural humility; and acknowledgement of intellectual property as well as the provision of meaningful feedback to communities
Samuels & Ryan (2011)	United States; special needs students	Describes how culturally relevant democratic inquiry (CDI) might be applied to school-based evaluations	Framework guideline	Scholars	CDI is typically implemented by an internal evaluation team comprised of school staff, students, parents, and an external consultant and involves focusing the CDI, utilizing the data, determining next steps, and developing a plan of action
SenGupta et al. (2004)	United States	Overview of policy and program views on cultural competence, as well as cultural and contextual methodologies	Review	Scholar	Argues that achieving cultural competence requires self-reflection and challenging existing power differentials; the development of policies and practice guidelines for cultural competence in evaluation; and multicultural evaluators
Slaughter (1991)	United States; Hawaiian schools	Describes how bilingual researchers can improve cross-cultural evaluation teams	Evaluation case application	Scholar	Although there are potential threats to validity when it comes to cross-cultural evaluations, the inclusion of bilingual researchers, who are knowledgeable about the culture of a group, can enhance the relevance of an evaluation; bring credibility to the process; and mobilize findings in a more meaningful manner
Stickl Haugen & Chouinard (2019)	North America	Reviews 18 studies and emphasizes the need to employ collaborative approaches and explore participant views on power	Framework/guideline	Scholars	Outlines a conceptual framework for thinking about power, which includes four dimensions: relational; political; discursive; and historical power. Argue that evaluators must carefully consider what methods they use; that collaborative processes should be employed; and that power should be a central focus of all evaluations
Stitt-Bergh et al. (2016)	North America; higher education institution	Discusses how evaluators can work with educators to ensure evaluations attend to CC and contextual factors	Opinion/reflection	Scholars and evaluators	In the context of higher education, evaluator roles include coordinating data collection, documenting the use of findings, and collaborating with faculty to publish
Symonette (2004)	United States; higher education institution	Discusses the process of developing cultural competence with a focus on diversity, multicultural validity, and interpersonal validity	Opinion/reflection	Evaluator	To become a culturally competent evaluator, one should engage in reflective practice, develop an awareness of diversity and power relations, and aim to establish multicultural validity
Thomas (2002)	New Zealand; Māori	Offers framework for assessing cultural competence, and emphasizes outcome indicators as well data collection methods	Framework/guideline	Scholar	Outlines a preliminary framework designed for evaluators to assess the cultural appropriateness of services; dimensions that could be taken under consideration include staff training, program environment and effectiveness, and practices
Thomas & Parsons (2017)	United States; African American	Presents combined CRE and systems-oriented evaluation (SRE) strategy to guide evaluation questions and offer new insights into results in STEM field	Evaluation case application	Scholar and evaluator	Argues that integrating CRE and SRE approaches can result in more meaningful evaluations, facilitate community engagement, and enhance the relevance of findings
Waapalaneexk-wew [Bowman-Farrell] (2018)	United States; Indigenous	Illustrates how Indigenous knowledge can be used to frame evaluations, with emphasis on working with communities and building local evaluation skills and capacity	Opinion/reflection	Scholar	Encourages the blending of Western and Indigenous evaluation methods; the recognition of colonizing practices, past and present, that have contributed to pain in Indigenous communities; the application of traditional practices in evaluation knowledge and competencies; and the engagement of Indigenous evaluators as co-investigators, among other recommendations

Opinion/reflection articles = Articles that presented ideas or general reflections and descriptions. Evaluation case application = Articles that present or discuss a particular evaluation.

CRE required evaluators to have shared lived experiences with participants (Bowen & Tillman, 2015; Hood, 2001; Manswell-Butty et al., 2014). Hood (2001) stated that when both evaluators and participants share some relevant life experiences, evaluators can provide a more accurate critical analysis.

3.2.2. Power in culturally responsive evaluation

Over half of the articles addressed the interaction and different cultural interpretations of power dynamics and how this can impact the evaluation process (Rhodes, 2016). The importance of shared responsibility, authority and ownership with community members in the evaluation was one strategy to reduce the potential harms of decision-making and ownership being solely held by the academic members of an evaluation (i.e., Askew et al., 2012; Prado, 2011; Thomas & Parsons, 2017). This was described as transferring power from members of the research team to community members, both philosophically and practically (Mertens, 2016; Waapalanekweew [Bowman-Farrell], 2018; SenGupta et al., 2004).

As a further response to power imbalances between evaluators and community members, CRE was highlighted as a pathway to community empowerment (Acree & Chouinard, 2020; Aponte-Soto et al., 2014; Botcheva et al., 2009; Chouinard, 2014; McDonald, 1999). Empowerment in evaluation refers to "increased self-determination and/or liberation of program participants" (McDonald, 1999, p. 172) throughout the evaluation process. Based on the premise that sharing decision-making and ownership with community members creates the space for their cultural realities to shape the evaluation process, different authors discussed empowerment as an essential component of culturally responsive evaluation (Acree & Chouinard, 2020; Aponte-Soto et al., 2014). Empowerment was also discussed as an outcome of evaluations that attend to cultural structures, histories, and norms. When community members are meaningfully included in the evaluation process, they can build their related knowledge and skills to become culturally responsive practitioners in their own right (Aponte-Soto et al., 2014). One article (McDonald, 1999) described empowerment as an approach to evaluation in itself, where prioritizing power-sharing with community members, in turn, enhanced its cultural responsiveness.

3.2.3. Approaches to conducting culturally responsive evaluations

There was a significant degree of overlap between CRE and the use of collaborative and participatory evaluation approaches. Embedded in community engagement to acknowledge and include cultural considerations in the evaluation process, collaborative and participatory approaches share the same foundational methodological practices and similar objectives (Chouinard & Cousins, 2009). Consequently, several articles used the terms 'collaborative' and 'participatory' interchangeably, or used one term or the other to refer to community engagement (e.g., Botcheva et al., 2009; Boyce, 2017; Dinh et al., 2019a).

A collaborative approach to evaluation was discussed more frequently in the literature and was characterized by "an important and definitive shift... from an approach that only considers the evaluator framework or worldview to an approach in which evaluation is collaborative and driven by [community] knowledge" (Botcheva et al., 2009, p. 179). Across these articles, a collaborative approach was considered necessary in ensuring an evaluation was culturally responsive. This included partnering with community members to include their culturally rooted concerns, values, and perspectives in the evaluation design and modifying the evaluation implementation accordingly, which generated findings that were culturally relevant (Acree and Chouinard, 2020; Askew et al., 2012; Botcheva et al., 2009; Dinh et al., 2019a). Some authors argued that the co-learning and power-sharing aspects of a collaborative approach were as important as the evaluation outcomes (Chouinard and Cousins, 2009; Stickl Haugen and Chouinard, 2019). Others stated evaluations could only be truly collaborative if cultural considerations were foregrounded in the evaluation (Askew et al., 2012;

Dinh et al., 2019a).

The term 'collaborative approach' was applied to all of these studies. However, there was a significant degree of variability regarding how collaboration was used to address culture in the evaluation. In some cases, a collaborative approach referred to the inclusion of community members' cultural knowledge and experiences in the evaluation design (Conner, 2004; Manswell-Butty et al., 2014), while in others, it included their active participation in the stages of implementation (Chouinard & Milley, 2018). One article (Collier et al., 2018) specifically employed a community-based participatory research (CBPR) framework in its evaluation and drew on the foundational principles of equitable involvement of community members, co-learning, and empowerment to improve the quality and validity of the evaluation.

4. Discussion

This review illustrates the differences in how CRE is understood and practiced, which is in part due to the context in which an evaluation is conducted. Context shapes "the questions we address, the design and methods we choose, [and] the ways in which we report our findings" (Rog, 2021, p. 25). For this reason, it is important that the cultural and sociopolitical context of the community inform the process, and this becomes critical for ensuring the responsiveness of the evaluation. In complement to Frierson et al.'s (2010) guide to conducting culturally responsive evaluations, this review has identified common distinguishing elements characteristic of a general CRE approach to offer direction for evaluators and practitioners working in the social-serving sector. Furthermore, key considerations that are important to tailor each evaluation to fit the local context are discussed. This section discusses the opportunities and strengths of these findings in relation to this study's primary research questions and examines some of the knowledge and practice of CRE that emerged from this study.

4.1. How is culturally responsive evaluation understood by evaluators?

Across the articles included in this study, community engagement, cultural competence, interpersonal competence, and shared lived experience emerged as elements of CRE. Moreover, these elements consistently appeared in the evaluation literature as essential to ensuring evaluations enhance social justice and are methodologically valid (Askew et al., 2012; Botcheva et al., 2009; Hopson, 2009). Notably, these elements were applied differently across studies, such as employing varying conceptions of community engagement or degrees of shared lived experience, for instance. These differences reveal the complexity of the concept of culture in itself, and the many ways in which it can be understood and applied to evaluation. Further, these differences reinforce the role of context in shaping how cultural responsiveness is practiced in evaluation.

4.1.1. Community engagement

Community engagement was most frequently associated with CRE, since engaging community members ensures that the evaluation process encompasses their worldview and verifies the interpretation of findings as culturally valid (Conner, 2004; Zulli & Frierson, 2004). Community engagement was referred to as consultation with community groups at the beginning of an evaluation in some instances (Conner, 2004; Manswell-Butty et al., 2014), and in others, community members were engaged as partners in all stages of the evaluation (Chouinard & Milley, 2018). Although the extent of community engagement was not consistent across the literature examined in this review, it is clear that including community members meaningfully in the process is foundational to CRE practice.

4.1.2. Power

CRE also fundamentally encompasses questions of power related to who participates, to what extent, and whose knowledge is prioritized

(Stikl Haugen & Chouinard, 2019). Articles included in this study commonly identified considerations of power as essential to CRE, where community members' knowledge and experiences are intentionally sought out and included. All aspects of the evaluation process, including its design, implementation, outcomes, and application, are shaped by the power relationships between evaluators and community members (Cardoza et al., 2002). How power is negotiated determines the extent to which community members inform and shape the evaluation process in each context (Stikl Haugen & Chouinard, 2019), making considerations of power inseparable from CRE.

It is important to note that the current literature reviewed situates evaluators as possessing the ability to decide how, and to what extent, power is shared with communities and cultural groups (Rhodes, 2016; SenGupta et al., 2004; Stikl Haugen & Chouinard, 2019). The authors note that situating power in this way may be problematic as it perpetuates the perception of academics and evaluators as experts and community members in need of paternalistic processes, instead of recognizing the power and deep contextual knowledge they possess of their communities and the critical importance of this in the evaluation process. As such, using a culturally responsive approach to evaluation does not necessarily correlate to an equitable balance of power with communities.

4.1.3. *Employing collaborative and participatory approaches in CRE*

Collaborative or participatory approaches are commonly applied to CRE. These approaches highlight the importance of meaningful collaboration with community members, as well as recognizing and attending to power dynamics (Askew et al., 2012; Chouinard & Milley, 2018). In research, participatory action research (PAR) and community-based participatory research are commonly applied frameworks based on the same principles of community engagement and power sharing that are also bolstered by a set of principles and methods (Chevalier & Buckles, 2019; Wallerstein & Duran, 2008). Although CBPR offers a process for community engagement that is rigorous, authentic, and equally viable in evaluation as in research, only one article explicitly drew on a CBPR research framework as a grounding for their evaluation (Collier et al., 2018). Other articles used participatory or collaborative approaches to evaluation (Botcheva et al., 2009; McDonald, 1999), and in a few cases a research framework or evaluation approach was not mentioned at all (Alindogan, 2019; Mertens & Hopson, 2006). This could be due to the limited scope of journals that were included in this review; evaluations that use a CBPR approach may be found outside of evaluation journals, published in community-oriented or engaged scholarship journals (e.g., Gokiart et al., 2017).

In her article, McDonald (1999) outlined seven broad guidelines centred around community engagement to conduct evaluations in cross-cultural settings, which include: community member participation, community member education, use of culturally appropriate methodology, feedback to community members and community-level usefulness of evaluation findings, enhancement of community member capacity, meaningful partnership, and cross-cultural evaluation teams. While this is not explicitly mentioned in McDonald's article, these guidelines and the foundational principles of participatory approaches to research share distinct similarities, particularly related to meaningful partnership with community members, usefulness of findings to communities, and community members' capacity-building (Chevalier & Buckles, 2019; Wallerstein & Duran, 2008; Tremblay et al., 2020; Janzen et al., 2017). Other included articles discussed the same aspects of CRE such as meaningful partnership (Alindogan, 2019) or community member education (Aponte-Soto et al., 2014); however, they also stopped short of employing the established research frameworks of CBPR and PAR in their studies. Consequently, although the similarities are clear between participatory and collaborative approaches used in CRE, and CBPR and PAR frameworks used in research, these approaches to research appear to be largely absent from CRE.

4.2. *Implications for culturally responsive evaluation practice*

As Frierson et al. (2010) point out, "it may seem obvious to some, if not to most, professionals that cultural responsiveness should be an integral part of the project development and evaluation process" (p. 77). Cultural structures, histories, and norms influence every dimension of the evaluation process and its actors (Chouinard, 2014). In particular, culture influences the perceptions and actions of both evaluators and community members as their understanding of a program and its evaluation is influenced by their culturally-rooted beliefs, values, and knowledge (Chouinard & Cousins, 2009; SenGupta et al., 2004). It is important, then, to map current CRE practices in order to identify their strengths and gaps.

The articles included in this review consistently highlighted that best practice in CRE centres on involving community members meaningfully in the evaluation process and equipping evaluators with fundamental skills, particularly cultural knowledge and self-awareness. When evaluators and community members collectively draw on their culturally informed worldviews and collaborate to make decisions, it is possible to understand the effectiveness, benefits, and outcomes of initiatives more fully for communities, demographic groups, and other "less-powerful" community members (Hood, 2001, p. 22). Furthermore, the community's lived experiences and worldviews should shape the evaluation questions, data collection methods or tools, and communication of findings to yield new explanations and conceptions of an initiative (Hopson, 2009) that are more accurate, meaningful, and useful (Rogers et al., 2017).

CRE aims to improve the conditions of underrepresented and underserved community groups by conducting valid evaluations (Askew et al., 2012; Hopson, 2009). Valid evaluations reduce inaccuracies in assessment, interpretation and representation, which occur when evaluators presume an understanding of culture and culturally-based discrimination (Askew et al., 2012; Nelson-Barber et al., 2005). Evaluators using this approach must recognize the ethnocentric nature of their biases and assumptions and reflect on how these influence the lens they apply to the evaluation process (Botcheva et al., 2009). Furthermore, they must "execute their work in ways that invite and legitimize diverse perspectives and complex understandings" (Askew et al., 2012, p. 554). As such, the findings from this scoping review suggest that CRE can address questions of social justice in assessment, methodological coherence, and data validity.

In practical terms, an evaluation is considered culturally responsive if it includes the cultural lens of its members or participants and entirely considers the culture in which the initiative being evaluated is situated (Frierson et al., 2010). Consequently, CRE typically engages community members with lived experience of the given culture in the stages of the evaluation process (Botcheva et al., 2009; Rogers et al., 2017). Furthermore, evaluators who bear the primary responsibility for the evaluation process must possess knowledge of, and the ability to, navigate cultural considerations, have appropriate interpersonal competencies, and ideally, have shared experiences with community members. Stokes et al. (2011) state that evaluators must be self-reflective and capable, with the ability "to share in and empathize with the lived experience..., [and] know the fine print of a culture and act in a culturally responsive way" (p. 168). In short, based on the articles included in this review, CRE requires evaluators to become "students in culture" (Askew et al., 2012, p. 554), as they uphold the cultural appropriateness of the evaluation as a whole.

The majority of articles applying a collaborative or participatory approach to CRE suggests that community engagement is inseparable from the process and should be guided by specific principles and steps. Drawing on the research frameworks of PAR and CBPR would extend their foundation of best practice to the field of evaluation, and would ground evaluation practice in an approach that is driven by principles of engagement that could strengthen collaboration with community members (Janzen et al., 2017; Tremblay et al., 2020). Consequently,

from a methodological perspective, utilizing PAR and CBPR to guide community engagement has the potential to enhance evaluation rigour as well as cultural responsiveness, and boost overall impact at the community level.

Power and culture are inextricably linked together (Kirkhart, 2010), and despite an increase in focus on CRE that attends to and considers issues of power, unequal ownership and decision-making authority between evaluators and community groups persists (Hood, 2004; Stikl Haugen & Chouinard, 2019). As numerous articles in this review discussed, empowering community members is a typical response to imbalances of power (Cohen, 2012; Easton, 2012; McDonald, 1999; Symonette, 2004; Waapalaneeckweew [Bowman-Farrell], 2018). Empowerment occurs by designating decision-making to community members at critical stages in the evaluation process (Brown & Di Lallo, 2020), and engaging with cultural issues of importance to community members through evaluation (Acree & Chouinard, 2020). As such, culturally responsive evaluators should acknowledge the inherent power differences that exist and work to minimize these differences as much as possible by intentionally including and collaborating with community members. Evaluators must reflect on their role and use their covert and overt authority to “construct an infrastructure for deliberative forums in which power differentials can be mitigated” (Cardoza et al., 2002, p. 34) between evaluators and community members. CRE requires shifting the narrative of power even beyond something that needs to be balanced and negotiated, but rather, as something that needs to be created collectively in order to achieve change.

4.3. Practical recommendations and resources

Context is first and foremost in culturally responsive evaluation and, as a result, the way in which evaluators adapt their approaches and methods will vary by community. Nonetheless, there are foundational principles and practices that lead to cultural responsiveness in the evaluation process. This section outlines several practical recommendations for enhancing the quality, validity, and cultural responsiveness of evaluative work.

To obtain trustworthy data, it is recommended that evaluators and practitioners reflect on their underlying values, biases, and assumptions and question the ways in which these belief systems can influence the evaluation process. Drawing on their experiences as outsiders conducting research with Hausa-Fulani Muslim women in Nigeria, Joseph et al. (2021) have created a guide to reflexivity for those working within a cultural group different than their own, and is comprised of the following: (1) outlining the identities of the researchers and participants involved; (2) considering the researchers' identities in relation to those of the participants with a focus on sensitivity, vulnerability, and cultural identity; and (3) addressing the reflexive questions provided in the article prior to commencing a study to proactively mitigate any potential challenges. Kallos (2020) provides a brief description of reflexivity in evaluation and also proposes several strategies for engaging in self-reflection, like allocating time at the end of every evaluation phase to identify limitations and areas of improvement, debriefing with team members, and checking-in with colleagues to solicit feedback on practices.

As highlighted in the thematic analysis, ensuring the meaningful inclusion of community members is foundational to culturally responsive practice. It should be noted that the appropriate degree of engagement can vary depending on community capacity and level of comfort with participating in an evaluation; this is where relationship-building and prolonged contact with the community can help establish rapport, which may in turn facilitate engagement. The International Association for Public Participation (2018) has developed a spectrum outlining different levels of community engagement—with increased influence as the scale progresses further to the right—that may prove useful for evaluators and practitioners who need assistance with defining the role of community members in their projects. Frierson et al.

(2010) provide concrete steps to integrating a culturally responsive approach into the evaluation process in partnership with community members, from question formulation to data collection to interpretation and use of findings. Other examples and resources exist to support culturally competent evaluation (e.g., American Evaluation Association, 2011; Centres for Disease Control and Prevention, 2014; Hood et al., 2015), including equitable, community-engaged and community-based approaches to evaluation and evaluation capacity building (see Author website).

Those undertaking CRE should also consider issues of power and authority and strive to minimize these differences. Bekes et al. (2017) have created a number of checklists that are intended to support evaluators and practitioners in applying the principles of equity and cultural humility in their work. These resources include questions designed to promote critical thinking and challenge evaluator biases in ways that can enhance the equity of evaluations. The Canadian Journal of Program Evaluation is an open-access journal that has recently begun publishing a permanent section titled *Roots and Relations*, which aims to honour Indigenous-led contributions to the field of evaluation. Although specific to Indigenous scholarship, this section may contain innovative approaches to “culturally grounded” evaluation (Bremner & Bowman, 2022, p. 11) that could be applied to other contexts and populations. By incorporating such practices in evaluative projects, it is possible to enhance the cultural and contextual responsiveness of this work.

4.4. Lessons learned

This section summarizes the key takeaways of our scoping review.

1. Community engagement, cultural competence, interpersonal competence, and shared lived experience emerged as core elements of CRE. These elements were applied differently across the included studies, revealing the complexity of CRE and the various ways in which it can be understood and applied. Further, these differences emphasize the role of context in shaping how cultural responsiveness is practiced in evaluation.
2. Best practice in CRE centres on involving community members meaningfully in the evaluation process. This means that the community's lived experiences and worldviews should shape the evaluation questions, data collection methods, and communication of findings, and that decisions pertaining to the evaluation should be made collaboratively.
3. There was major overlap between CRE and the use of collaborative evaluation approaches, which included partnering with community members to include their perspectives in the evaluation design, or encouraging their active participation in the implementation of the evaluation.

4.5. Limitations and future research

While this review has identified important learnings related to the practice of culturally responsive evaluation, it is not without methodological limitations. Since this study restricted its review to evaluation-based journals, only nine journals were searched during data collection. Articles describing a specific type of cultural evaluation (e.g., Indigenous evaluation, evaluation with immigrants/refugees) without a more general exploration of culturally responsive evaluation were excluded to maintain the focus and feasibility of this scoping review. However, this is a critical area of exploration and would warrant a review on its own similar to the one that was conducted by Drawson et al. (2017) on Indigenous Research Methods. To complement this review, an examination of literature outside of evaluation journals, as well as grey literature, would be useful. Much of the culturally responsive evaluation occurring at the community level may be reported in grey literature or organizational websites, especially in cases where community organizations are not partnered with a university.

Just as this study found community engagement to be a critical component of CRE, in conducting this review, we included community partners in the analysis of findings. However, limited resources and time constraints precluded the inclusion of these partners in planning or conducting the review according to their cultural structures, histories, and norms. Future reviews could instead be conducted using a culturally responsive lens. As one of five reviews being conducted by the (Evaluation Capacity Network) (i.e., Bourgeois et al., 2023; Puinean et al., 2022), this article contributes to understanding the current state of evaluation and informs strategies for enhancing the use of culturally responsive practice in the social serving sector. This has the potential to contribute to evaluations that are equitable, relevant, and useful to both evaluators and communities.

5. Conclusion

This review explored how evaluators understand and practice CRE, and how literature to date can shape it going forward. The results have revealed key learnings on the current state of knowledge and practice in CRE. Although still a relatively new field, common components of CRE are emerging which can be applied to practice. At its core, evaluations adopting a CRE approach tend to consider cultural structures, histories and norms, and engage community members meaningfully to ensure that the evaluation process and findings encompasses their worldview. Further, CRE equitably negotiates the power dynamics that inherently accompany community engagement. It is hoped that the results presented in this paper are helpful for evaluators and community practitioners who are looking to learn more about CRE in general, and incorporate a CRE approach into their practice.

Funding Source

This work was supported in part by a Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council (SSHRC) Partnership Grant.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Lauren Kushnier: Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Writing – original draft. **Shevaun Nadin:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Resources, Supervision, Project administration. **Mary Ellen Hill:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Resources, Supervision, Project administration. **Mischa Taylor:** Formal analysis, Writing – original draft. **Shelly Jun:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Project administration. **Christopher J. Mushquash:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Resources, Supervision. **Giulia Puinean:** Writing – review & editing. **Rebecca Gokiart:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Resources, Writing – review & editing, Visualization, Project administration, Funding acquisition.

Declaration of Competing Interest

None.

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